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Evolution of Houthis: Local movement to Red Sea power

Moinuddin Ahmad
New Delhi, September 22

THE RAPID advances made by the Yemeni armed group Houthis along the Red Sea coast and around the Bab el-Mandeb Strait have left Saudi Arabia's oil exports and shipping exposed in the critical sea lane. This comes after Iran's effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz since the war in West Asia broke out in February.

Origins as localised group

Ansar Allah's journey began in the 1990s as a Zaidi Shia religious and cultural revivalist movement against the alleged neglect the community faced at the hands of the Sunni rulers, who came to power in 1962 after a revolt against the Zaidi Imamate that ruled Yemen for over a thousand years. The Zaidi Shias, who felt marginalised amid the rapid expansion of Saudi-funded Sunni proselytisation, looked up to their leaders, including Hussein Badreddin al-Houthi, who established a group called al-Shabab al-Mu'min (The Believing Youth) in 1992 aimed at preserving cultural identity.

By the early 2000s, the movement began political activism against certain policies of Yemeni President Ali Abdullah Saleh and the 2003 US invasion of Iraq. The group criticised Saleh's government for its

alignment with the US and Saudi Arabia. Tensions grew into an armed insurgency in 2004 when Yemeni security forces attempted to arrest Hussein al-Houthi. His death in a battle later that year militarised and consolidated the movement under his family's leadership, launching six successive wars against the Saudi-backed government between 2004 and 2010.

Prasanta Kumar Pradhan, research fellow and coordinator, West Asia Centre, at the Manohar Parrikar Institute for Defence Studies and Analyses (MP-IDSA), told *The Indian Express*: "During the six Saada Wars (2004-2010), the central Yemeni government struggled to suppress the insurgency. Saudi Arabia directly entered the conflict in late 2009 after Houthi fighters crossed into the border region of Jizan. The Saudi military relied on heavy airpower and artillery but faced operational challenges in the rugged mountainous terrain, previewing the tactical difficulties that would characterise future campaigns."

Parallel state

Over a decade of territorial control, the Houthis transitioned from an insurgent militia into a governing authority that manages a highly lucrative war economy. Through systematic restructuring of the state, the group, which included institu-

The Houthi worldview

● The group's worldview is articulated in its controversial slogan, the Sarkha: 'God is great, death to America, death to Israel, a curse upon the Jews, victory to Islam'.

● Its modern ideology borrows heavily from global anti-imperialist rhetoric and Iran's 1979 Islamic Revolution.

● The Houthis view themselves not merely as a local political faction but as a sovereign vanguard fighting against Western hegemony and monarchies in the neighbourhood.

tions and the private sector, established a comprehensive parallel economy.

Rana Friefer, writing for *Al Majalla*, notes that recent economic assessments indicate that the Houthi administration generates roughly \$2.5 billion annually through parallel tax and collection mechanisms. The Houthis are said to have prioritised the energy sector. Through state-run bodies like the Yemen Petroleum Company, the Houthis manage the distribution of fuel, divert shipments to black markets, and manipulate prices. The US Treasury Department has also accused the Houthis of generating more than \$2 billion annually through the illicit trade of Iranian oil.

'Axis of Resistance'

While Houthis are generally dubbed as a direct Iranian proxy, some see the relationship through the prism of strategic alignment, technical dependency, and mutual benefit. Tehran provides support that elevates Houthi capabilities. The Houthis give Iran a strategic footprint along the Bab al-Mandeb and the southern flank of Saudi Arabia. This presence provides Tehran with asymmetric leverage over global trade routes.

Domestically, the Houthis exhibit autonomous decision-making. Despite depending on Iranian assistance, the Houthi leadership makes decisions based on do-

mestic needs and political survival.

A regional player

According to Pradhan, the Houthi capture of Mayun Island, along with their seizure of the strategically important port of Mokha along the Red Sea coast, has considerably strengthened their position along these critical maritime corridors.

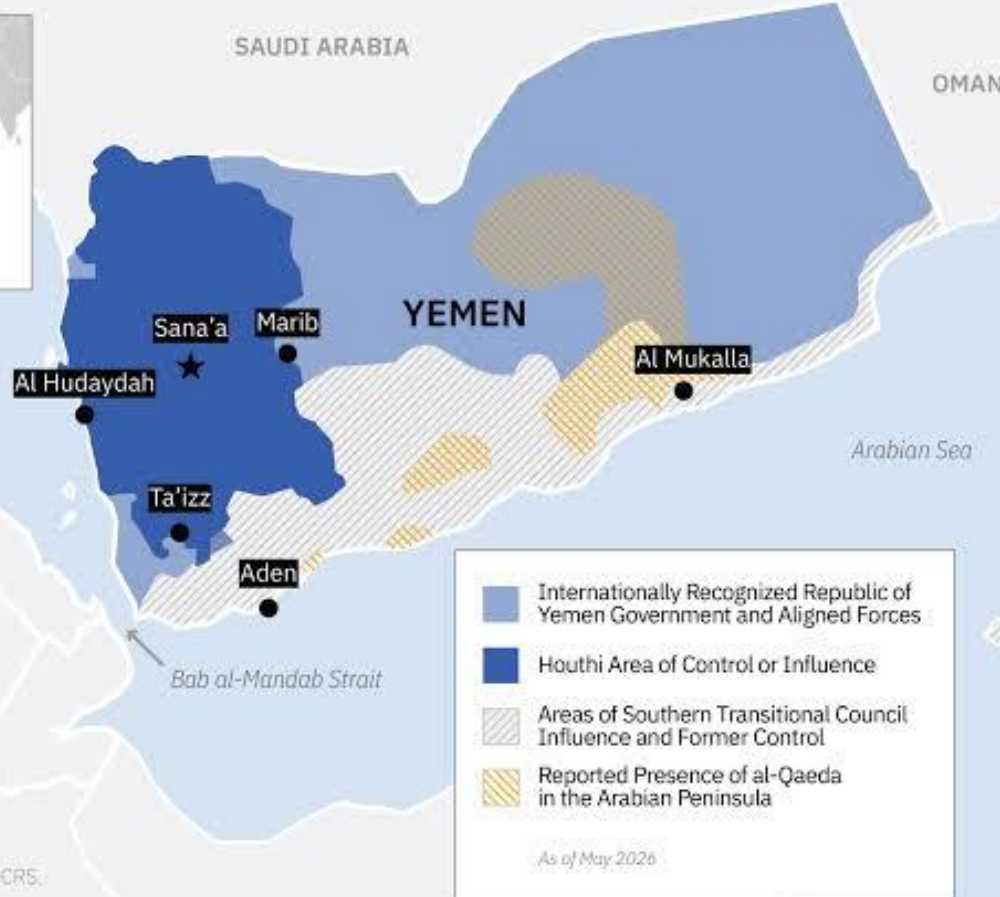
"Much as Iran has demonstrated that it holds effective power over the Strait of Hormuz and the capacity to disrupt maritime security in its vicinity, the Houthis are now projecting themselves as the dominant force in the Bab el-Mandeb and the Red Sea... the growing instability in the Red Sea and the Bab el-Mandeb poses an increasingly complex security challenge for the Yemeni government, Saudi Arabia and for the wider regional order," he said.

The Houthis' participation in regional security dynamics complicates diplomatic engagement between the US and Iran. A major diplomatic hurdle is the disconnect between Iranian influence and true Houthi independence. Although Washington blames Tehran for supplying the Houthis with weapons, the group acts with substantial operational freedom — meaning Iranian pledges to reduce tensions do not guarantee Houthi restraint.

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Yemen Areas of Control, Influence, and Operation



A Zaidi religious revival movement in Yemen's northern Saada province in the 1990s

The Saada wars (2004–2010)
Under **Hussein al-Houthi**

Arab Spring to takeover of Sanaa (2011–2014)

Entrenchment as a de facto state (2015–2022)

Red Sea power: from coastal control to global disruption (2023–2026)

India's vast canal network offers a land-free path to solar power

Similar to floating solar, the biggest advantage of canal-top photovoltaics is that they require virtually no additional land, especially as land acquisition for large-scale solar is also becoming increasingly expensive; in Punjab, the installation of 20 MW of canal-top systems is estimated to have saved nearly 100 acres of land

Shantanu Roy

As India expands its clean energy capacity, finding land for solar projects is becoming a challenge. This is driving interest in innovative solar solutions that can generate power without needing more land.

The recently approved PM Surya Sarovar Yojana (PM-SSY) is a step in this direction, aiming at developing 5,000 MW of floating solar capacity on reservoirs and other inland water bodies across the country.

However, India's water infrastructure has more to offer: the country's vast canal network – one of the largest in the world – is another under-explored avenue to generate solar power. Built over existing irrigation and water-supply canals, canal-top photovoltaics (CTPV) provides a unique approach to turn them into clean energy assets.

In CTPV, solar panels are mounted on specialised structures built over canal stretches. Unlike floating solar systems, where panels are installed on floating platforms on water bodies, CTPV systems use elevated structures above the canals. Systems can be built based on the canal's width, design, and orientation. The elevated structures may span the canal or can be installed along the canal banks. In all cases, the design must allow unobstructed water flow.

Advantages of CTPV
Similar to floating solar, the biggest advantage of CTPV is that it requires virtually no additional land. With land acquisition for large-scale solar becoming increasingly challenging and expensive, CTPV offers a promising way by using India's canal infrastructure. For instance, in Punjab, the installation of 20 MW of CTPV systems is estimated to have saved nearly 100 acres of land.

CTPV offers another advantage. With solar panels covering canal stretches, the amount of water lost to evaporation can be reduced. This can be particularly useful in India's water-stressed regions. The cooling effect of the water beneath the panels could improve panel performance in hot weather. A 1-MW CTPV system over the Narmada Canal in Mehiana, Gujarat, commissioned in 2012, reportedly saves close to 9 million litres of water every year while generating 1.6 million units of electricity annually.

While CTPV remains largely a niche application, India has been an early adopter, with its first installation in Mehiana in 2012. Between 2014 and 2017, two 10-MW CTPV systems were commissioned in Vadodra, Gujarat, and 20 MW of CTPV systems were commissioned in Punjab between 2017 and 2018.



Solar panels seen installed above the Narmada canal in Chandrasan village, Gujarat, in 2012. The State hosted India's first canal-top photovoltaics. AP

In September 2025, the Punjab Energy Development Agency invited 'expressions of interest' for 40-MW CTPV projects across Punjab's canal network, spanning over 10,000 km. Haryana has also initiated efforts to explore CTPV systems over six of its irrigation canals.

CTPV also received policy support in 2014, when the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) launched a pilot-cum-demonstration scheme for grid-connected CTPV and canal bank projects with a target of 50 MW each for CTPV and canal-bank projects. The scheme also included financial assistance of Rs 3 crore and Rs 1.5 crore per MW or 30% of project cost, whichever was lower, for CTPV and canal bank systems, respectively.

An assessment in 2024 (co-authored by CSTEP, where the author works) estimated India's CTPV and canal bank potential at around 131 GW (for canals up to 30 m wide and vertical bifacial

installations for canals over 30 m wide). Considerations such as solar irradiation, canal characteristics, distance from substations, and protected areas were included in the assessment to identify the best-suited canal stretches across India. The five States with the highest potential were Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, and Punjab.

Potential roadblocks

Despite India's early progress, deployment has remained limited for more than a decade after the first installation.

High system cost is the primary bottleneck. CTPV systems are more expensive than ground-mounted ones as they require elevated structures to span canal stretches. These structures need to be designed to not disrupt canal operations and be sturdy enough to withstand winds. They also need additional structural steel, foundations,

and access provisions for operations and maintenance, all of which add to the overall costs.

Maintenance tasks, including cleaning panels and replacement and repair work, can also prove difficult when the structures are elevated above a working canal.

The linear nature of CTPV systems, which run along the course of canals, can also pose challenges when canals follow irregular paths or change direction. This can increase the cost of producing electricity, especially when electrical substations or transformers are not strategically located.

Renewed policy approach
PM-SSY is expected to revitalise the floating solar segment and drive its adoption across India, signalling growing policy interest in exploring land-neutral solar applications. This focus could extend to other solutions like CTPV, potentially giving the technology greater policy attention and momentum.

However, to overcome the aforementioned structural challenges and scale CTPV deployment, identifying and prioritising suitable canal stretches will be critical. Factors such as land scarcity, nearby electricity demand and grid connectivity, and canal orientation and geometry should be considered while selecting sites to maximise the economic viability of CTPV systems.

CTPV also requires accessible and tailored financing mechanisms, including viability gap funding and low-cost debt, to make it an attractive option for developers. This will help support early projects, allowing developers to build experience and eventually reducing costs through scale and standardisation.

However, the 2014 MNRE scheme on CTPV shows that financial support alone may not suffice to convert pilots into large-scale deployment.

A renewed policy approach that includes financial assistance and standardised specifications and guidelines, capacity building of state nodal agencies, irrigation departments, and other concerned agencies, and streamlined process flows is required.

While CTPV may not fully substitute ground-mounted or rooftop solar, they offer an untapped opportunity for India's renewable energy expansion. Even if a fraction of CTPV's technical potential is realised, it could significantly boost India's renewable energy capacity without adding to the pressure on land resources.

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THE GIST

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Systems can be built based on the canal's width, design, and orientation and elevated structures may span the canal or can be installed along the canal banks

With solar panels covering canal stretches, the amount of water lost to evaporation can be reduced, which can be particularly useful in India's water-stressed regions

PM Surya Sarovar Yojana PM-SSY

5000 MW of floating solar capacity on reservoirs and other inland water bodies.

Canal top photovoltaics (CTPV)

Built over existing irrigation and water-supply canals.

India's estimated potential at around 131 GW

PM Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana

Rooftop solar scheme subsidised upto 3kw

PM-KUSUM Component A supports 500 kW–2 MW decentralised ground/stilt-mounted renewable-energy plants,

Agrophotovoltaics, also known as agrivoltaics or agrisolar, is the dual use of the same land for both agricultural crop production and solar photovoltaic electricity generation

Secular, religious, non-religious: How Constituent Assembly debated UCC

Jatin Anand

New Delhi, September 22

ARTICLE 44 of the Constitution, part of the Directive Principles of State Policy, says: "The State shall endeavour to secure for the citizens a uniform civil code throughout the territory of India." Directive Principles guide the State but are not enforceable by courts. The Constituent Assembly placed the UCC there after a long and spirited debate on November 23, 1948, when it took up what was then draft Article 35.

Against the UCC

STATE 'TYRANNY': Mohammad Ismail Khan, the United Provinces Member from the Muslim League, argued it was unnecessary "to compel people to give up their personal law" with the objective to "secure harmony through uniformity".

B Pocker, Madras Member from the Muslim League, said "a guarantee" of the liberty to follow personal laws was available even during the British rule. "...and let it not

be taken that I am only voicing forth the feelings of the Mussalmans. In saying this, I am voicing forth the feelings of ever so many sections in this country who feel that it would be really tyrannous to interfere with the religious practices, and with the religious laws, by which they are governed now," he said.

ARTICLE 19: Naziruddin Ahmad, Member from West Bengal representing the Muslim League, argued that interfering with personal laws clashed with Article 19 of the Draft Constitution, which provided for freedom of conscience and the right freely to profess, practise and propagate religion.

Aspects of the British Civil Procedure Code, Ahmad said, had already "interfered with our personal laws and very rightly so", but during the 175 years of British rule, they "did not interfere with certain fundamental personal laws." What the British in 175 years, he said, "failed to do or was afraid to do, what the Muslims in the course of 500 years refrained from doing, we should not give power to the State to do all at once".



B R Ambedkar, chairman of the Drafting Committee. WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

SECULARISM: Mahboob Ali Baig, who represented Madras, said his view was that the words "Civil Code" do not cover the "strictly personal law of a citizen" and as far as the Muslim community was concerned, their laws of succession, inheritance, marriage

and divorce "are completely dependent upon their religion."

Syed Hussain Imam, Member from Bihar, said a secular State does not mean that "it is anti-religious...not irreligious but non-religious and as such there is a world of difference between irreligious and non-religious." "...we should first await the coming of that event when the whole of India has got educated, when mass illiteracy has been removed, when people have advanced, when their economic conditions are better, when each man is able to stand on his own legs... Then, you can have uniform laws," he said.

For the UCC

'TYRANNY OF MAJORITY': KM Munshi, a Congress Member from Bombay, questioned the argument that the enactment of a Civil Code would be tyrannical towards minorities. He said nowhere in advanced Muslim countries had the personal law of each minority been recognised "as so sacrosanct as to prevent the enactment of a Civil Code." "When you

want to consolidate a community, you have to take into consideration the benefit which may accrue to the whole community and not to the customs of a part of it. It is not therefore correct to say that such an act is tyranny of the majority."

ARTICLE 19: Munshi sought to clarify in regard to Article 19 that the House had already accepted the principle that if a religious practice covers a secular activity or falls within the field of social reform or social welfare, it would be open to Parliament to make laws about it without infringing this Fundamental Right of a minority.

SECULARISM: Munshi said the main question was whether the members of the Constituent Assembly were going to "consolidate and unify our personal law in such a way that the way of life of the whole country may in course of time be unified and secular." "We want to divorce religion from personal law, from what may be called social relations or from the rights of parties as regards inheritance or succession. What have these things got to do with religion I

really fail to understand..." Munshi said. **WOMEN'S UPLIFTMENT:** Munshi also sought to underline that a common code for the entire country was required to uplift the status of women in independent India.

Ambedkar on UCC

Responding to Hussain Imam, B R Ambedkar said India already had a uniform code of laws covering "almost every aspect of human relationship" in the form of a uniform and complete Criminal Code. The only province the Civil Law had "not been able to invade so far", he noted, was Marriage and Succession. "It is this little corner which we have not been able to invade so far and it is the intention of those who desire to have Article 35 as part of the Constitution to bring about that change..." he said.

There were, to Ambedkar, other possibilities, in which a future Parliament "may feel the ground" by making adherence to a common civil code "purely voluntary".

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Article 44: The State shall endeavor to secure for citizens a Uniform Civil Code throughout the territory of India. To establish a common set of personal laws for all citizens regardless of community.

Courts have repeatedly invoked Article 44 rhetorically — from **Shah Bano (1985)** through **Sarla Mudgal (1995)** to more recent observations — treating **Articles 14 (equality) and 21 (dignity)** as pulling toward uniformity in ways that qualify how far **Article 25's religious-freedom** guarantee extends into civil matters.

Uttarakhand enacted a Uniform Civil Code in February 2024 (in force from January 2025), and **Gujarat** passed its own UCC Bill in March 2026, making it the second state to do so,

Saving the rhino, restoring grasslands



BHUPENDER
YADAV

FOR INDIA, the greater one-horned rhinoceros is much more than an iconic species. It is an integral part of the ecological and cultural landscape of the Brahmaputra floodplains and the Terai grasslands. The animal's historical range extended across the northern Indian Subcontinent, along the Indus, Ganga and Brahmaputra river systems. Today, its wild population in the country is concentrated mainly in Assam, UP and West Bengal. Under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's leadership, India is now pushing for the expansion of the rhino range.

The rhino conservation strategy is guided by the understanding that conservation should not be limited to safeguarding existing rhino concentrations but should work toward establishing secure populations across suitable parts of their historical range. The National Conservation Strategy for the rhinoceros, launched in 2019, provides a framework for strengthening existing populations, restoring the species to suitable former habitats, maintaining genetic security and habitat connectivity, promoting scientifically planned translocations and building climate resilience into rhino conservation.

The rhino's story in India is a story of recovery. The animal's numbers have increased from around 1,500 in the 1980s to more than 4,000 as of September 2024.

The five-year Phase I (2026-2031), proposed for support through the National CAMPA Authority, brings together Assam, Arunachal Pradesh, Bihar, Uttar Pradesh and West Bengal, with a focus on scientific monitoring, protection, habitat restoration and management, translocation planning, coexistence and capacity building. It seeks not only to consolidate the existing populations but also to support the species' expansion into suitable areas in Bihar and Arunachal Pradesh.

The rhino's habitats are also important for swamp deer, wild buffalo, elephants, tigers, grassland birds and several smaller species. Grasslands are dynamic ecosystems that require science-based management to prevent degradation, inappropriate succession and the spread of invasive species. The Rhino Conservation Action Plan provides for mapping grasslands and wetlands, identifying invasive species, prioritising habitats for intensive restoration and developing protected area-specific management protocols.

This species-focused effort is comple-

mented by a national initiative. A five-year (2026-2031) project on the Comprehensive Assessment of Indian Grasslands, to be implemented by the Wildlife Institute of India, Indian Council of Forestry Research and Education and Forest Survey of India, will assess grassland extent, ecological condition, biodiversity, degradation, ecosystem services and carbon potential. It will support a National Grassland Atlas, restoration priorities and long-term management guidelines.

Flooding is intrinsic to landscapes such as Kaziranga. But the increasing frequency and intensity of extreme climatic events can create new conservation pressures. Maintaining access to higher ground, securing ecological connectivity, protecting dispersal routes and managing habitats will be important. The National Conservation Strategy recognises climate-resilient management as part of the protection framework for the species.

Technology, too, has an expanding role. Modern surveillance, spatial monitoring, veterinary diagnostics, genetic tools and decision-support systems can reinforce traditional fieldcraft. No technology, however, can substitute the forest guards, watchers, mahouts, veterinarians and field officers who patrol these landscapes. Equally important are the communities living around rhino habitats. The future of the species depends on conservation being seen not as an isolated governmental activity but as a shared enterprise.

India's experience has also shown the importance of cooperation beyond state and national boundaries. At the Second Asian Rhino Range States Conservation Meeting held in New Delhi in 2019, India joined Bhutan, Indonesia, Malaysia and Nepal in adopting the New Delhi Declaration to strengthen conservation cooperation for Asian rhinoceros species. The Centre and the rhino-bearing states have since continued to work within this broader framework.

On World Rhino Day, September 22, we take satisfaction in the distance travelled. In protecting rhinos, we are also protecting the rivers, grasslands, wetlands, forests and communities that together make these landscapes among India's richest treasures. The rhino's recovery is a national achievement. Its future is a national responsibility.

The writer is Union Cabinet Minister for Environment, Forest & Climate Change

National Conservation strategy for the Rhinoceros 2019 Brahmaputra flood plains and Terai lands Assam, UP, West Bengal



Grasslands are dynamic ecosystems that require science-based management to prevent degradation, inappropriate succession and the spread of invasive species



Extinct



**Extinct in
the Wild**

Out of all species that have ever lived, 99.9% of them are now extinct. The IUCN has documented 830 species known to have gone extinct since 500 AD.

Currently the IUCN has 69 species listed as extinct in the wild. These species have been extirpated from their natural range and now exist only in captivity.



Threatened (*encompasses CR, EN, and VU*)



**Critically
Endangered**



Endangered



Vulnerable

To be listed as threatened, a species must fit one of the following qualifications

A projected population decline of greater than ____ over the next 10 years or three generations

80%

50%

30%

A global range of less than ____ km²

100

5,000

20,000

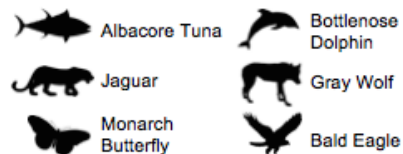
A stable global population size of less than ____ individuals

50

250

1000

*Two other categories exist, although they have more complicated thresholds: small population size AND decreasing population, or quantitative scientific analysis that shows a high likelihood of extinction.



**Near
Threatened**



**Least
Concern**

Near threatened species are in danger of becoming threatened. Species with least concern listings may still have declining populations or face threats, but not to the level required for a threatened listing.

Out of the RedList's 77,000 listed species, 35,000 are listed as least concern and 5,000 are listed as near threatened.



For species that have yet to be sufficiently evaluated, two additional classifications exist: data deficient (DD) and not evaluated (NE).

Water wealth

Groundwater exploitation in Punjab disincentivises small farmers

That Punjab is over-extracting groundwater is not news. According to the 2025-26 Dynamic Groundwater Assessment, its groundwater extraction rate was 152%. While interventions reduced the number of 'over-exploited' blocks by five over the last two assessments, 72% of its 153 blocks are in the 'red zone', the highest among States. The principal consumer is irrigation for rice and wheat, amounting to nearly 25 billion cubic metres a year in the latest estimate. Data also show that the fraction of observation wells with water below 40 metres in the post-monsoon period grew by two percentage points between 2022 and 2025. What began as a strategy to improve food security eventually yielded a concentrated rice-wheat cropping system, in which assured procurement, subsidised electricity and access to groundwater made high-yield varieties, intensive irrigation and fertilizer use and mechanisation less risky than alternative modes of cultivation. In the same vein, the reluctance of the region's farmers to pursue other crops due to uncertainties in storage options, prices, processing infrastructure, and supply chains has gone relatively unaddressed. But as the water crisis persists, the wealth gap among farmers is also widening. A recent study in the *Economic and Political Weekly* noted that while farmers with marginal landholdings use water more efficiently, wealthier farmers are better equipped to access lower water tables as well as draw higher volumes. So, as the water table drops, those unable to afford the requisite tube wells are forced to buy water, transferring their wealth to larger landowners and creating unregulated dependencies. A different study by two members of the same team, published in *Discover Sustainability*, reported that in Sangrur and Barnala, larger farms earned higher returns but recorded lower groundwater productivity vis-à-vis paddy, than smaller farms. Effectively, groundwater depletion raises the capital required for irrigation, which systematically privileges those farmers with better access to finance.

State governments continue to attempt to address the demand pressure in multiple ways even as the scale continues to overwhelm the resulting gains in efficiency. At this juncture, together with those efforts, the State should also endeavour to protect farmers' incomes and access to irrigation while rendering the cost of additional extraction prohibitive. The '*Pani Bachao, Paisa Kamao*' scheme, in which farmers are entitled to cash for every unused kilowatt-hour (for pumping) under a threshold, is already promising, albeit with low enrolment. Broadly, the State should use part of the electricity subsidy bill to directly support smallholder farmers, help collectivise irrigation infrastructure, and/or support farmers' transition to other crops. When benefits follow the cultivator, including tenants, rather than owners of the land or pumps, welfare can subsidise access to water rather than groundwater extraction.

Punjab extracts groundwater at 152% of annual recharge, with 72% of its blocks in the red zone, driven primarily by an entrenched rice-wheat cycle

How Policies Locked In Over-Extraction

Assured Procurement

Subsidised Power

The Rice-Wheat Cycle

Why Crop Diversification Has Failed

Market and Supply Chain Gaps

Storage and processing infrastructure

Entrenched Politics

Major hot deserts in northern hemisphere are located between 20-30 degree north and on the western side of the continents. Why?

Thank you

“The price of success is daily effort”



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